

CASE REPORT

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01 Issue Statement

Beyond Meat mirrored Silk's strategy of placing its products beside original options but overlooked the difficulty of convincing daily meat-eaters to switch to plant-based alternatives. In addition, its poorly defined target audience, non-competitive pricing, and narrow concentration on frozen food aisles in grocery stores provide little incentive and limited visibility for customers to purchase its products.

02 Situational Analysis

The SWOT and STP models are chosen because they work well together to identify and target Beyond Meat's strategic mismatch. SWOT shows what the company does well and what it needs to work on inside, as well as the threats from outside rivals and the opportunities it has to grow. At the same time, the STP model solves the main issue of defining who the correct audience is. This helps Beyond Meat narrow its market focus, divide its customers into groups, and position its brand. The models work together to find and solve the main problems that were brought up in the issue statement.

SWOT Analysis

Strengths

- Strong Purpose: The company started with a focus to promote sustainability and better health through plant-based diets.
- Technological and R&D Innovation: They developed technology that replicates the texture and taste of meat, giving them a competitive edge.
- Nutritional Advantage: Their products offer similar protein to real meat while containing only half the fat.
- Early Market Penetration and Partnerships: Beyond Meat achieved early distribution success through Whole Foods and expanded rapidly to over 5,000 retail stores across the U.S. by 2014.

Weaknesses

- Unclear target audience: Beyond Meat struggles to define whether its products are aimed at meat-eaters or vegetarians, leading to inconsistent messaging.
- Incorrect targeting method and an unrealistic strategic assumption: They wants all meat eaters to switch to plant-based diets, which is an unrealistic short-term aim. They ignored the cultural, sociological, and emotional ties of meat in U.S. diets.
- High price: Beyond Chicken (8oz) costs about $5.99, while organic chicken costs about $5.45; there is no pricing benefit.
- Weak channel strategy: The reliance solely on frozen food aisles restricts visibility, while exposing to competition from other frozen items.

S W O T

Opportunities

- Repositioning Consumer Segments: Focus on university students, flexitarians and health-conscious people who are open to reducing, rather than eliminating, meat consumption.
- Strategic Partnerships and Co-Branding: Collaborate with fast-food and fast-casual restaurants to switch their meat with Beyond Meat's products. Introducing Beyond Chicken in popular chicken-based menu items would be strategic since chicken eaters are typically more health-conscious than beef eaters, and chicken also offers better plant-to-animal protein conversion efficiency (20% vs. 10% for beef).
- Diverse Distribution Channels: Increase in-store visibility through supermarket tastings, food-court sales, and placement beyond just frozen meat aisles.

Threat

- Intensifying Competition: Other plant-based brands (e.g., Impossible Foods) and large food conglomerates (e.g., Nestlé's Awesome Burger) increases competition. High prices and significant innovation costs could hurt Beyond Meat's sales.
- Perception of Frozen Products: Even when plant-based foods are good for health and the environment, their 'frozen' aspect may make them seem less healthy and make them less desirable to health-conscious customers.
- Conflicting Name: The word "meat" in the name can create confusion. Vegetarians may associate it with animal products and avoid it altogether, while meat eaters might view it as an artificial or "fake" substitute rather than a genuine protein option, reducing their likelihood of purchase.

Key Takeaways/ Implications

The SWOT analysis shows that Beyond Meat's main challenge does not lie in its product, but in how it executes and markets its strategy. Its Silk-inspired approach oversimplified the difficulty of shifting consumer behavior and failed to define a clear target audience. Furthermore, its high prices and limited presence in frozen aisles reduce visibility. Looking ahead, Beyond Meat can take opportunities by repositioning toward young health-conscious individuals, expanding availability through partnerships and experiential marketing, and introducing student-focused promotions.

STP

Segmentation

The alternative meat industry is primarily composed of younger consumers, particularly those between 18–24 years old. 45% of people in all age categories eat meat substitutes, compared to 31% of all customers. This shows that a lot of the growth is coming from millennials and Gen Z consumers who are willing to shift their diets. The market is health- and sustainability-conscious, and people are very aware of food safety and how it affects the environment. The main customers are flexitarians, who eat meat but are attempting to cut back on it. Strict vegetarians and people who only eat meat are not the main customers.

Targeting

Beyond Meat currently markets its products to health-conscious people by showing they are high in protein, low in fat, and cholesterol-free. Additionally, the company's objective to "create mass-market solutions that perfectly replace animal protein with plant protein" suggests they aim to appeal to people who are not yet accepting meat alternatives. However, this target audience is not effective because vegetarians or health-conscious people who care about the environment are likely already buying plant-based alternatives, whereas major meat-eaters will probably never change their eating habits. Instead, they should go for those who are on the fence or who are okay with switching but don't know what their options are. Therefore, Beyond Meat should narrow its focus and position specifically with segments of young adults who are university students and young professionals who still eat meat but do not have a fixed purchasing habit yet. Typically, they are urban, educated, and whose purchase decisions are linked to fitness, social image, and environmental values. Additionally, Beyond Meat should target chicken and poultry consumers more heavily, who tend to be healthier than beef eaters. As Beyond Meat chicken alternatives contain comparable protein, less than half the fat, and added fiber, chicken eaters are more likely to adopt them.

Positioning

Beyond Meat defines itself as a food technology company that changes the way consumers experience protein, offering the taste and texture of meat through plant-based ingredients. Their value proposition is about being able to enjoy the food while making better choices for their health and the planet. Their product also matches real meat protein but contains significantly less fat and no cholesterol. The packaging is created to look like regular meat packaging, and the placement in grocery stores is intended to be in the meat aisle. This positioning strategy is intended to overcome psychological barriers around meat-eating by designing the product and brand experience to feel as familiar as possible. At the same time, the company also keeps the environmental and animal welfare parts of its goal open but not obvious in its advertising to consumers.

Key Takeaways/ Implications

The STP analysis shows that Beyond Meat's main market consists of younger, health- and sustainability-conscious consumers, aged 18–35 who want to reduce meat intake rather than eliminate it. Its current broad targeting has limited effectiveness, so the company should narrow its focus to university students, young professionals, and chicken consumers who are open to switching. Beyond Meat is successfully positioned as an innovative food technology brand offering realistic, nutritious plant-based meat alternatives that promote health and environmental responsibility.

03 Decision Criteria



Cost (Initial Investment & Ongoing Expenses) - 15%

This criterion looks at how much money it will take to put the option into action, this includes costs such as research and development, marketing, production, partnerships, and long-term operations expenditures. The higher the cost, the lower the score.



Market Reach - 30%

This criteria shows how likely the alternative is to bring in new clients and grow Beyond Meat's audience beyond only their original customers. It measures how successfully the solution gets the attention of the groups such as flexitarians, young adults, and other groups of consumers that were not considered their target audience. The more market reach, the higher the score.



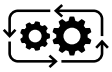
Brand Image Impact - 15%

This criteria looks at how each option improves Beyond Meat's brand reputation, consumer trust, and emotional connection. It considers whether the option aligns with Beyond Meat's mission of promoting health, sustainability, and innovation or risks diluting it. The higher scores reinforces Beyond Meat's intended image while a low score suggests dilusion of brand image.



Profitability - 25%

This criteria looks at the predicted financial return and long-term profitability of each option. This includes the possibility of making a profit, the ability to grow, and the chance of making repeat purchases. The purpose of this criteria is to see if the alternatives can generate and sustain profits in the long run to offset the high production costs.



Complexity of Implementation - 5%

This criteria looks at the difficulty to carry out each option, such as changes to operations, partnerships, and changes to the supply chain. The more complex an alternative is, the lower the score, as it carries more operation risk and higher risk of failure.



Differentiation and Competitive Advantage - 10%

This criteria evaluates how well each option helps Beyond Meat distinguish itself from its competitors, whether its other plant-based brands or traditional meat companies. The more differentiation or unique advantage the alternative offers, the higher the score.

Explanation for Weights

The weights are determined by each criterion's relative importance. Price is significant, but it's not the most important. While expensive R&D and marketing costs hurt profits, strategic expansion and market adoption are more important. Market reach is the most important factor since Beyond Meat's biggest problem is that it doesn't reach enough people and doesn't target them well. To get new customers, the company needs to expand its market reach, which directly fixes the organization's strategic mismatch. Brand perception is somewhat significant because Beyond Meat needs to change its image from a niche vegan brand to a mainstream lifestyle brand. Profitability is very important because Beyond Meat's long-term success depends on keeping up its expansion. Complexity of Implementation is not as important since it's worth it to handle more difficult operations if they make more profit. Differentiation is somewhat crucial because having a unique brand is quite important in a competitive market.

04 Alternatives

Status Quo - Alternative 1

Overview

Beyond Meat will keep the same marketing and product strategy that it has been using, which is heavily based on Silk's success in the dairy sector. The company's mission to "replace animal protein with plant protein" will stay the same. Beyond Meat will keep focusing on improving the taste, texture, and nutrition of its plant-based meat products to make them as close to real meat as possible. The company continues to position its products as mainstream alternatives sold primarily in the frozen sections of grocery stores, alongside traditional meat items, to encourage buying among meat-eating consumers.

Beyond Meat maintains a heavy emphasis on research and development (R&D) as well as marketing investments aimed at changing consumer perceptions and normalizing plant-based meat consumption. They will aim for acceptance of plant-based protein as a regular dietary choice, rather than a complement. While this strategy has helped the company establish strong brand recognition, it also keeps Beyond Meat operating within the same category and consumer mindset.

Pros

- Brand mission alignment: This strategy keeps Beyond Meat's image as a first-mover in the U.S. for sustainable, healthy, plant-based meat alternatives.
- Established reputation and credibility: Keeps the continuing momentum from early success with retailers like Whole Foods.
- Operational stability: The company does not have to change its approach, which saves time and money and to continue focusing on research and development.
- Appeal to original audiences: Still serves vegan and vegetarian consumers as well as trying to change the habits of traditional meat-eaters. This requires less effort and resources needed to target other segments.

Cons

- Limited mainstream adoption: They believe that meat-eaters can easily transition, but this ignores the cultural significance of meat. The current strategy will not see significant growth in a short period of time.
- Weak market targeting: Beyond Meat's broad focus on "all health-conscious consumers" makes its messages unclear and doesn't resonate with any specific groups such as vegans, vegetarians, flexitarians or meat-eaters.
- High marketing and research and development costs: Sticking with the same approach means keeping up with high fixed costs, making it difficult to lower prices and remain competitive.
- Limited visibility: Focusing on grocery stores, particularly frozen aisles, makes it harder for customers to see and access the brand.

Weighted Average: 2.35/5

Rating Breakdown:



Cost (Initial Investment & Ongoing Expenses)

2/5



Market Reach

2/5



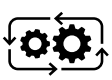
Brand Image Impact

3/5



Profitability

2/5



Complexity of Implementation

4/5



Differentiation and Competitive Advantage

3/5

Explanation

While this alternative has minimal implementation complexity and keeps a strong brand image, it does not have advantage in its profitability and market reach criteria. Thus, continuing the current strategy would maintain stability but limited long-term growth and acceptance, which could lead to risk of survival in the industry in the long-run.

In Industry - Alternative 2

Overview

In-industry strategy focuses on redefining the target audience and using multiple channels to reach them.

Redefining the target audience:

- Directly target young adults, including university students and young professionals from ages 18-35.

Channels to reach audiences:

- Rebrand: shift from "Beyond Meat" to "Beyond Bite".
- Pricing strategy: offer lower pricing and student discounts, and partner with universities flex dollar programs.
- Retail placement: place near frozen vegetables, meat aisles, and ready-to-eat meals; launch their own frozen burgers and breakfast sandwiches.
- Experiential marketing: conduct taste tests and sampling in supermarkets.
- Collaborations and partnerships: Co-brand with Chick-fil-A and collaborate with major U.S. sports events.

Details

Firstly, Beyond Meat would redefine its target audience to young individuals aged 18 to 35, including university students and young professionals. This group is more open to trying new foods as many have just started living independently and have not yet developed fixed grocery habits. In addition, they are generally more environmentally conscious.

Not only does Beyond Meat need to refine its target audience, it also needs to change the way it reaches them. The first step to do this is to change its brand name from "Beyond Meat" to "Beyond Bite". The word "Bite" closely resembles "Byte", a computer science term associated with technology and new solutions. This subtle play on words positions the brand as forward-thinking and modern. "Beyond Bite" would thus shift people's mindset to go beyond traditional ways of getting protein from meat to healthier protein alternatives.

Beyond rebranding, to effectively engage students, Beyond Meat would work with universities and colleges to include its products in meal plans, campus dining, and flex-dollar programs. It would also provide student discounts to get students to try the products.

Beyond Meat should change its product placement. Beyond Meat would make its products more visible by also putting them next to frozen veggies and frozen meats because increasing placement areas will make them more exposed to customers. In addition, Beyond Meat would add more types of products to its line. Since burgers make up the biggest part of the alternative meat market, the company would start making its own frozen burgers. Breakfast sandwiches are also another product line they will make as breakfast is arguably one of the most important meals of the day and having healthy pre-made breakfast is convenient and will incentivize customers to buy. These products will be placed in the ready-to-make meals section.

Apart from retail placement in frozen foods, Beyond Meat should give customers the opportunity to get a real taste of its fresh products. This can be done through in-store taste tests where their frozen products are sold. The freshly created sample will let customers taste for themselves, before heading over to frozen aisles to purchase them.

Moreover, to promote their products beyond grocery stores, Beyond Meat will have co-brand collaborations with popular fast-food restaurants such as Chick-fil-A. This allows them to create new items on their menu that combine Beyond Meat's chicken alternatives as the source of proteins in Chick-fil-A's sandwiches. For example, the company could launch a plant-based version of the original Chick-fil-A Chicken Sandwich, labeled as Chicken Sandwich, with the plant icon linking to details about the collaboration and ingredients. As sales grow, Beyond Meat could expand into additional offerings like a plant-based Grilled Chicken Sandwich. This allows Beyond Meat to benefit from Chick-fil-A's strong popularity among young customers. Overall, these strategies will make Beyond Meat's freshly made products be more widely available for consumers to try, and help boost the sales in its frozen products.

Lastly, Beyond Meat would use event-based marketing to get more people to see and buy their products during big U.S. sports events or other times when meat is usually the main dish, like football games. This strategy puts Beyond Meat right in front of people who are used to eating burgers, nuggets, and sandwiches. This encourages people to try it and makes plant-based substitutes ease in everyday life more smoothly. All these components in this alternative combined would open up will target young audiences more directly and offer more exposure and incentive for customers to buy Beyond Meat's products.

Pros

- Clearly Defined Target Market: Beyond Meat has focused its target market on young adults, ages 18–35 years, who are more accepting of new diets and sustainability. Partnerships with universities through student meal plans and flex-dollar programs introduce the product early to young consumers. This builds brand loyalty and normalizes plant-based eating in student life.
- Better Product Placement: Locating the products next to both frozen meats and vegetables gives more visibility. This on-shelf positioning would be drawn to vegetarian, flexitarian, and health-conscious consumers, as well as meat-eaters.
- Expanding Product Line: Using market share of plant-based alternative statistics, the introduction of frozen burgers and breakfast sandwiches will enable Beyond Meat to capture multiple consumption occasions and drive brand awareness.
- Fast-Food & Restaurant Partnerships: Putting its products in Chick-fil-A heightens visibility within mainstream meat consumers and young adults. This places Beyond Meat products in places where customers are more familiar, thus making them more acceptable.
- Competitive Pricing: After marketing cost cuts and a price adjustment, Beyond Meat will start to be much more affordable to mass consumers, hence solving one of its main obstacles to being competitive.
- Updated Brand Identity: Removing "Meat" by rebranding the name to something like 'Beyond Bite' will provide an image of innovation, technology, and health.
- Event-Based Marketing Visibility: Beyond Meat uses event-based marketing at major sporting events or festivals, since those are high occasions of meat consumption to reach lots of new users in order to normalize the plant-based offerings.

Cons

- Risk of Brand Dilution: Taking "Meat" out of the brand name can make it seem more modern and adaptable, but it could also make it harder for current customers to recognize Beyond Meat right away.
- High Costs of Implementation: Launching new product lines, rebranding, and building partnerships with major retailers or restaurant chains all require significant financial investments.
- Operational Complexity: Beyond Meat will have to deal with more logistical problems as it grows into grocery stores, universities, and fast-food chains. It can be hard to coordinate supply, keep quality consistent, and run vast operations.
- Reliance on Partnerships: If Beyond Meat relies too much on partnerships to reach customers, including through restaurant chains or universities, they may not be able to control how its products are advertised, priced, and shown to customers.

Weighted Average: 4.1/5

Rating Breakdown:



Cost (Initial Investment & Ongoing Expenses)

3/5



Market Reach

5/5



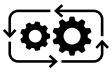
Brand Image Impact

4/5



Profitability

4/5



Complexity of Implementation

3/5



Differentiation and Competitive Advantage

4/5

Explanation

This alternative has moderate but manageable costs regarding rebranding, partnerships, and product development. The target includes young adults, students, and flexitarians; it addresses the weakness in the market reach of Beyond Meat. Campus programs, taste tests, and fast-food partnerships boost visibility. Rebranding to *Beyond Bite* might be some confusion in the short term, however, it has long-term growth. While moderately complex, coordination with a large number of partners allows for greater differentiation, with fewer competitors operating in both retail and fast-food channels.

Out of Industry - Alternative 3

Overview

The out-of-industry alternative would place Beyond Meat in a strategic position to expand its line of products into the pet food category, including foods and snacks for animals that are plant-based. It would enable Beyond Meat to apply its existing plant-protein technology knowledge beyond the human food category. With increasing awareness of sustainability and animal welfare, many owners have started to care about the carbon footprint and ethical implications of traditional pet food. Most of them consist of meat, so Beyond Meat would be well-placed to position itself as a nutritious, eco-friendly pet food and thus offer an alternative for pet owners looking to reduce their ecological footprint without jeopardizing their pets' health.

Beyond Meat would involve veterinarians, pet nutritionists, and large chains of pet stores with this line of products in order to create visibility and consumer trust. This opens new revenue streams for the company and makes it less dependent on the highly competitive plant-based human food market.

Pros

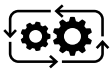
- New Market Opportunity: Extending into this new market will give Beyond Meat the opportunity to take part in a growing and less-saturated market with ethical pet care.
- Diversification of Revenue: Starting plant-based food in the pet industry will lessen the company's reliance on the competitive human food industry, making the profits more stable in the long term.
- Leverages Existing Technology: This approach will enable Beyond Meat to make pet food leveraging on its existing plant-protein technology without having to start from scratch.
- Strong Brand Alignment: Offering plant-based pet food fits well within Beyond Meat's mission to reduce meat consumption and environmental impact, further solidifying the company's brand image and message.

Cons

- R&D and Testing Costs: Creating safe and tasty pet food takes research and approval beyond the technology they already have to produce human food. These steps can be expensive and are challenging even with their existing technology.
- Limited Brand Recognition in the Pet Market: Beyond Meat is known for its human food products, but not yet known in the pet food market. The recognition would take effort and time.
- Possible Brand Dilution: Expanding beyond human food could blur Beyond Meat's main identity, potentially confusing customers about whether the brand focuses on human food or pet food.
- Operational Complexity: Moving into a completely new industry means developing new supply chains, marketing strategies, and distribution systems. This complicates existing operations.

Weighted Average: 3.15/5

Rating Breakdown:

					
Cost (Initial Investment & Ongoing Expenses)	**Market Reach**	**Brand Image Impact**	**Profitability**	**Complexity of Implementation**	**Differentiation and Competitive Advantage**
2/5	**3/5**	**4/5**	**3/5**	**2/5**	**5/5**

Explanation

The out-of-industry pet food alternative aligns with Beyond Meat's mission to provide sustainability and ethical pet food while reducing the reliance of human food. However, there are high costs and operational complexity, as well as uncertain profits and acceptance with this alternative.

05 Recommendation

Weighted Average

	Status Quo	In Industry	Out of Industry
Weighted Average	2.35/5	4.1/5	3.15/5

Summary

The in-industry alternative is the best choice for Beyond Meat currently as it takes into account brand awareness and long-term acceptance and growth potential. The in-industry strategy lets Beyond Meat grow within its current market while also reaching out to a younger, more responsive audience, like college students and young professionals. This is different from the status quo, which limits the company to its current marketing approach and a small group of customers.

The in-industry method is much more reliable and cheaper in the short term than the out-of-industry pet food option. It draws on Beyond Meat's strengths, like its well-known product range, retail distribution channels, and production capabilities, without needing big investments in research and development or new regulatory processes. Beyond Meat can make its products more visible and easier to get by changing prices, improving product placement, and working with fast-food restaurants and universities. This will help the company stay efficient and get more recognition over time. The in-industry alternative is an essential step before all other actions to address their target audience, price, and limited reach issues.

06 Action Plan

Timeline

Timeline	Action
Months 1–4: Research, Planning, and Partnership Development	• Conduct market research on student and young professional food habits, meal trends, and preferred purchase locations across the U.S. • Begin discussions with universities to include Beyond Meat in meal plans, flex-dollar programs, and on-campus dining halls. • Reach out to Chick-fil-A for details of collaboration. • Start working with branding consultants to update the brand name and visuals, and finding ways to existing customers to accept the change. • Finalize marketing and operations budget allocations for implementation; Develop a targeted pricing strategy to make Beyond Meat products more competitive.
Months 5–9: Rebranding and Initial Launch	• Fully rebrand Beyond Meat's identity by introducing 'Beyond Bites' and create new packaging across all product lines. • Launch student programs at several selected universities to start Beyond Meat's new promotional strategy. • Place products in frozen veggies and meat aisles and begin grocery store taste sampling where customers can taste freshly prepared Beyond Meat products. • Start developing their own new product lines such as frozen burgers and breakfast sandwiches. • Start launching co-branding products with Chick-fil-A that uses Beyond Meat's plant-based chicken alternatives. • Use data from point-of-sale (POS) systems to see how often people buy the products, how often they repurchase, and what products go well together. • To see which placement has greater sales, compare the outcomes of products that are shelved near frozen meat with those shelved near frozen veggies.

Timeline (continued)

Timeline	Action
Months 10–13: Retail Expansion and Performance Tracking	• Keep running in-store and campus promotions, and give large discounts especially for the start of school and holiday seasons, including "Buy One, Get One Free" bundles. • Expand distributions with more university dining programs and more Chick-fil-A locations. • Fully roll out their own frozen breakfast sandwiches and burgers in grocery stores. • To continue monitor performance, keep track of digital engagement statistics like coupon redemptions, discount utilization, and social media likes and comments. • Analyze sales performance by location (universities, grocery stores, and fast-food chains) to identify top-performing locations and demographics. • Request sales and menu data from Chick-fil-A to evaluate menu item success and refine their strategies.
Months 14–18: Sports Events and International Growth Ideas	• Continue getting more grocery stores to carry their products; Use the information gathered on areas with the most demand and sales as choices of further expansion. • Collaborate with major U.S. sports events to increase visibility. Sell their products in large amounts with discounts and bundles, as well as offer free coupons with all purchases. • As sales rise and the company becomes known all across the U.S., start looking for partnerships in other countries, like Canada, to see if Beyond Meat's new branding and product range can be used in other parts of the world.